

Pack-2 The Brim



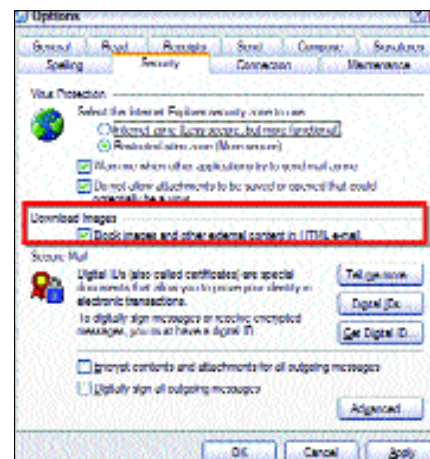
We take a sneak peek at Windows XP Service Pack 2, to show you what to expect

Security! That's what's on us Windows user's minds. Even Microsoft holds it as a top priority. A technical preview of Service Pack 2 (SP2) has been released Windows XP. This is downloadable from <http://www.microsoft.com/sp2preview/>—be warned, it's a 273 MB download, and still in its beta stage. The final release is

couldn't tell whether NAV was enabled or not. We couldn't even force SP2 to accept that NAV was indeed running fine.

SP2's firewall is a marked improvement over the simple Internet Connection Firewall that comes with Windows XP. The new firewall is turned on automatically, has a better user interface and better application control. The Exceptions tab let's you choose programs and services that should get uninterrupted Internet access. Using the advanced tab, you can change detailed settings for Network Connections, Security Logging and Internet Control Message Protocol.

Whenever a program tries to access the Internet, a dialog pops up asking you what action it should take. However, this is very buggy: both Windows Media Player and Opera could access the Internet without being allowed to do so—



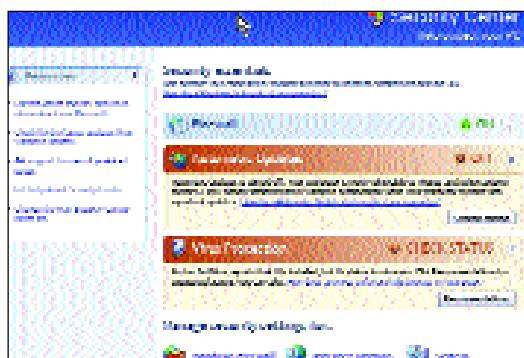
Outlook Express now blocks images in e-mail messages to protect your privacy

code is not executed from that memory. This will help prevent the very common buffer overflow-based attacks that occur in software as varied as browsers, e-mail clients and file-sharing services. Unfortunately, the only processors that currently support this are the AMD K8 and the Intel Itanium processor family—so until you upgrade your hardware, this technology is useless for you.

After a lot of complaints, Microsoft has finally added a pop-up blocker for IE in SP2. It was able to stop unwanted pop-ups and allow the genuine ones. SP2 also has an Add-on Manager for IE—it allows you to view, enable and disable Active X controls, browser extensions, Browser Helper Objects (BHO) and all the toolbars that are installed. Outlook Express can now block images in HTML e-mail, until you choose to display them. This also prevents spammers from validating your e-mail address and tracking when an e-mail is opened.

A lot of smaller features have also been added, such as the addition of the Bengali and Malayalam locales. SP2 also has a new command line tool called powercfg.exe, which can be used to access the Windows power policy settings (**Control Panel > Power Options**).

Though SP2 looks very promising, there's no point installing this beta release—we suggest that you wait for the final release.



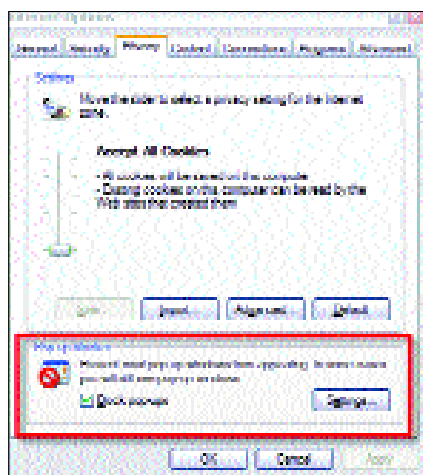
Security Center is the master control centre for firewall, automatic updates and anti-virus

expected at the end of 2004, so the beta may have bugs; even Microsoft states, "This technical preview is unsupported and is intended for testing purposes only. Do not use in production environments."

You'll be asked to enable Automatic Updates at the Welcome Screen. Both the Web interface, as well as the system interface for automatic updates has been revamped.

The Security Center is like a master control centre for three main aspects of your security—firewall, automatic updates and anti-virus. A red icon shows which is turned off, and you also get frequent balloon pop-ups that say, "Your computer might be at risk". SP2 was smart enough to recognise that Norton AntiVirus (NAV) was installed, but

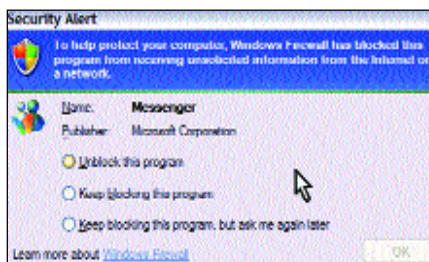
Internet without being allowed to do so—



Finally, IE users get an inbuilt pop-up blocker

it didn't detect Opera until a few days later. This is unacceptable, and will hopefully be fixed in SP2's final release.

To protect your memory from malicious code, Microsoft has introduced hardware-enforced Execution Protection, also known as NX. Processors that support this mechanism can prevent code execution from data pages, by marking a range of memory with an attribute, so that



A much improved firewall comes with SP2